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# Some uses of the head shake\*

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A context-of-use study is reported of the ‘head shake’. A large number of examples are described and compared, drawn from video recordings of naturally occasioned interactions in the circumstances of everyday life, made in Campania, Italy, central England and the Eastern United States. Eight different kinds of uses for the head shake are illustrated. It is concluded that the head shake is not to be understood simply as the kinesic equivalent of a unit of verbal expression. It appears as an expression in its own right which, furthermore, the speaker uses as a component in the construction of an utterance which, it seems, is so often a *multimodal* construction in which the different modalities of expression available are *deployed* by the speaker in the course of building a unit of expression according to the rhetorical needs of the interactive moment.

**Keywords:** gesture, negation, kinesics, conversation, multi-modal communication

The ‘head shake’ is perhaps the most well known of all head gestures, apart from the ‘nod’, and it is generally recognized, at least in cultures of Western European derivation, as a way of saying ‘no.’ It is often used as a gestural equivalent of this particle and, in many contexts, it can be directly translated by this. In virtue of this, indeed, the head shake could be regarded as a true ‘emblem’ in the well-known definition of Ekman and Friesen (1969:63). According to this definition, to qualify as an ‘emblem’ a gesture must have “a direct verbal translation or dictionary definition, usually consisting of a word or two or perhaps a phrase.” Yet, when we collect observations on when people employ the head shake, we find that its use is far from being confined to cases where it is the equivalent of some easily rendered verbal expression such as ‘No.’ Often, the only way in which its meaning may be rendered is by re-formulating

the speaker's entire utterance, often with additions that were not rendered verbally in the original. The head shake is used in many different discourse contexts where, although, as we shall argue, it can always be interpreted as expressing a 'theme' of *negation*, it yet comes to have a very different force, depending upon how this theme of negation combines with the other semantic themes that are also being expressed. We shall see how the head shake serves as an *operator* on spoken language meanings, often in ways that are similar to the way linguistic particles such as 'not' 'never,' and the like, function. It also serves in other ways, however, as when it is used to mark the evidentiary status of something that is said, as an expression which adds 'intensity' or 'force' to an utterance, or as a metacomment on the 'speech act' or 'move' that a speaker has engaged in. Head shakes participate in an important way in the linguistic meaning of an utterance, yet the way in which they do so is by no means always easily formulated in terms of equivalents in verbal expression. In a way, this should not surprise us. Why should we use gestures if they are just 'words' in another form? Yet they present us with a real challenge to our efforts to provide an account of how they mean.

To study the head shake allows us to find excellent demonstrations of the way in which, in the production of utterances, speakers can employ both kinesic and verbal expressions in *ensembles* that permit complex multilayerings of meaning. Kinesic expressions such as the head shake, because they can be varied in the length of time they take to perform and can be performed simultaneously the speaker's speech as well as in alternation it, can enter into relationships with speech in many different ways. Thus a head shake can stand on its own, as an utterance in its own right, as if it is the kinesic equivalent of a spoken particle, or it can occur simultaneously with speech to produce meanings that may parallel what is being expressed in words, or that may stand in various other relationships: additive, complementary or supplementary. These meanings, furthermore, may be related to the referential content of the utterance, to its illocutionary force, they may be related to the speaker's own stance with respect to what is spoken, or they may be related to the dialogic role of the utterance within the interactional sequence in which it is occurring.

There are few previous studies of the head shake. Spitz (1966), writing from a psychoanalytic perspective, has discussed the origin of the gesture as a 'refusal' and Jakobson (1972) has attempted a semiotic analysis in terms of the contrast between the 'shake' of 'no' and the 'nod' of 'yes.' Vávra (1976) and Collett and Chilton (1981) have followed up certain claims Jakobsen made about the direction of the movement by which a head shake is initiated. These studies all

take it for granted that the head shake is a gesture of negation and they do not include specific observations on the head shake in use. Observations on head shake use are included in McClave's (2000) study of the linguistic functions of head movements, and observations on the use of the head shake as an 'assessment marker' are found in Goodwin (1980) and Schegloff (1987). We will comment on these observations later. It is to be noted here that these publications only included the head shake as part of their focus, however. As far as we know, the present paper is the first to report an extended comparative study of the contexts of use of just the head shake.

## Definitions and methods

The 'head shake', as we define it here, is recognized whenever the actor rotates the head horizontally, either to the left or the right, and back again, one or more times, the head always returning finally to the position it was in at the start of the movement. Head shakes can be distinguished from head turns of various other kinds (such as turning the head momentarily to the left or to the right to glance at something, or to accomplish the 'look-away' that is common as a speaker initiates a turn at talk or initiates a new unit of discourse within a turn) because they are always performed within the 'frame' of the orientation the person is using, which may be either the orientation in use for a current turn at talk, or the orientation that a person is using as a recipient of another's utterance. Like all bodily actions that are recognized as 'gestures', indeed, the head shake is an *excursionary* movement — at the end of the head shake the head is back in the orientation it had at the moment it began.

Head shakes vary in terms of the amplitude of the head rotations employed, in the number of rotations and in the speed with which these are performed. There is no doubt that these variations in performance intersect with and modify the meaning of the gesture. Furthermore, the head shake may be combined in various ways with other movements, such as movements of the eyelids, mouth expressions, and gestures of the shoulders, such as the raising of the shoulder in a 'shrug' or with manual gestures of various kinds. In this paper, however, necessarily preliminary as it is in many ways, we have made no attempt to subdivide the head shake according to how it may be varied in its performance, nor do we attempt to explore its relationships with gestures of the face or other parts of the body.<sup>1</sup>

The method we have followed in this study has been to review a large number of video-recordings of naturally occurring occasions of interaction and to collect from these as many instances of the head shake as we could. The video-recordings were all converted to compressed digital format and instances of head shakes have been extracted and placed in separate folders.<sup>2</sup> In this way we have assembled a collection of head shake specimens which can be studied comparatively with great ease. Over sixty specimens have been studied. Those we have described here have been selected to illustrate the range of contexts-of-use that we have found for head shakes in our material. We do not claim that the uses we describe exhaust all of the possibilities. However, we do believe that most of the most common kinds of head shake use have been included.

For each example, the role of the head shake has been interpreted in relation to the overall meanings that are being expressed in the entire context of the turn-exchange in which the head shake occurs. The position taken in this paper is that the best understanding of the significance of the head shake is arrived at if it is assumed that the head shake may be interpreted as an expression of *negation*. As we shall see, although head shakes are often used in contexts in which the speaker is saying 'no' or making a negative statement of some kind, it is also often used when the speaker is making statements in which no negation appears on the surface and which, furthermore, may even express positive evaluations. Yet, as will be argued, in the spoken discourse in these cases there is a negation that is *implied* and it seems that the head shake is used as a way of expressing this. If the head shake is viewed in this way, the simplest and most general explanation for the diverse environments in which we see it used is provided. This even accounts well for seemingly paradoxical appearances of the head shake in discourse contexts where there seems to be no negation and positive statements are being made.

The video recordings from which the examples in this study have been taken are recordings that have been made in the course of acquiring material for a comparative study of gesture use in conversation in Naples and vicinity in Italy<sup>3</sup> and in a small town in central England. All these recordings have been made in the unstaged settings of everyday life and most of the occasions recorded are natural in the sense that they would have taken place whether or not they had been recorded by us. Some of the recordings are of interviews or conversations that were specially requested, however. These include interviews with Neapolitans about Neapolitan life, conversations in which people reminisce about their youth or describe some aspect of their everyday life, such as their job, the house they live in or their pets and other possessions, but in all

cases the discourse was unstaged, never provoked for the purposes of eliciting gestures of any particular kind and although the participants, all of whom freely gave their consent to the recordings, knew at the time of the recordings that these recordings were being made as samples of conversation, our special interest in gesture was only discussed, if it ever was, after the recordings had been made.

In quoting the examples the head shake is represented by a row of one or more 'plus' symbols, placed in brackets, thus <+>. Where the head shake occurs simultaneously with speech, this symbol is placed in the line immediately above the transcribed words, the duration of the head shake in relation to the words being shown by the length of the row of + symbols. Pauses in speech are represented by a point enclosed in round brackets. Brief pauses are represented by (.), more extended pauses by (....). In a few cases where it has been deemed appropriate to note the presence of a gesture other than a head shake, this is shown on a separate line with a row of different symbols, in most cases by a row of asterisks (<\*>).

### Summary of head shake uses

From the collection of examples that we have made so far, we have identified eight different ways in which the head shake is used. These are:

- I. The head shake is used as the equivalent of the verbal particle 'no' as this may occur in response to a yes/no question, for example. In this role the head shake serves as an utterance all by itself.
- II. The head shake is used in combination with verbal expressions of 'no' as if it is a kinesic parallel to the spoken expression. However, how the head shake is placed in relation to the verbal 'no' is variable.
- III. The head shake is often used as a component of a negative expression. Often, when a speaker is making a statement that contains a negation, a head shake is also employed as a part of the utterance.
- IV. A head shake is often employed in the course of an utterance in such a way as to express a meaning that is *in addition to* any meaning that is being conveyed in words. This can show itself as an expression of some move in addition to the move already being made by the current utterance (as in making a statement and, at the same time, giving a negative response to a question), or as an expression of the speaker's attitude toward the contents of the verbal component of the speaker's

- own utterance (as when a speaker shows disapproval of something he is describing or doubt about what he is asserting).
- V. A head shake is often employed simultaneously with speech where there is a negation *implied* by what is being said. In this way, the negation implied in the verbal expression is brought out, but in the kinesic modality only. Thus we see the head shake used in association with expressions such as 'I could do X but I will do Y' where *not* doing X is an implication of what the speaker says, or in expressions using 'only', as in 'This is the only thing you can do' where there is an implied *denial* of other possible lines of action.
- VI. A head shake is also seen in use when the speaker is making a statement for which no exceptions are allowed. We propose that in these cases, also, there is an implicit negation and it is the expression of this that accounts for the use of the head shake in these contexts.
- VII. Head shakes are seen in use when a speaker makes a superlative or intensified expression – as when saying something is 'very very old' or 'very very rare' or is '*bellissima* – most beautiful'. Rather as there is an implied negative in 'universal' statements so we believe that a negative is implied in these cases, and it is in terms of this idea that we account for the use of the head shake in these cases, also.
- VIII. The head shake is also used as a means by which a speaker can comment on his own utterance, as in self-corrections, or as when the speaker expresses doubt about what he is saying or doubt as to whether he has responded to his interlocutor appropriately.

### Examples illustrating head shake uses

**I. The head shake used by itself.** The first use of the head shake to be exemplified is its use as the equivalent of 'no' in response to questions or to other kinds of utterances to which the response 'no' is appropriate. First of all, here are some examples which show a person saying 'no' by using *only* a head shake. Example I.1 is from a situation in which adults (parents or other relatives) are bringing children to register for an activity organized at a local museum in a small town in Northamptonshire, in England. As part of this process, the children were asked where they lived. Thus:

Example I.1. (OMUSACT 2.13.56).

- H: (registering names and addresses) Leans toward child:  
Do you live in Barnwell?
- Child: <++>
- A: (child's aunt): No, its her cousin that lives in  
Barnwell

It is interesting to note how, in this example, the adult accompanying the child also answers the question, but verbally, and she also adds a statement which, here, perhaps is offered in mitigation of the fact, implied by H's question, that H, who is a very well-known resident of the town, had assumed (when perhaps he should not have done) that the child lived in Barnwell.

Example I.2 is taken from a recording made in Portici, near Naples, of an informal gathering of children who are members of a church parish association. They are meeting with an adult leader, MG, who asks one of the girls, T (who is about thirteen years old), if she knows how to cook. In reply she simply shakes her head. MG responds with '*Come no!* Why not!' and T then repeats her head shake. The moment this is over she adds a 'tongue-click' (represented as *zzt!*), which is a common oral gesture of negation in this part of Italy. Meanwhile, another member of the group volunteers that she does know how to cook.

Example I.2. Portici 2001 Puffi 02.00.18

- MG: Titi, tu sai cucinare, no?  
Titi, you know how to cook, don't you?  
<+++++++> <+++++++>
- T: zzt!
- MG: Come no!  
Why not!
- E: Io, si!

Example I.3 is again taken from the recording of the parochial gathering. Here AK (who is also the camera operator) has been having a short conversation with one of the girls (E, who is about thirteen years old) about her house. She has been describing the contents of her own bedroom and AK asks if she has a TV in her own bedroom. She replies with a head shake to say 'no' but immediately goes on to say where, in her house, TV sets are to be found.

Example I.3. Portici 2001. Stanze 2.06.26

- AK: Ha un ti vu?  
Have you got a TV?



- E: Si  
Yes
- G: =Si  
=Yes
- AK: Ne-nella stanza sua  
In your room?  
<+++++>
- E: Si, dentroooo alla stanza di pranzo  
Yes, inside the dining room
- G: =Nella stanza...  
=In the room...

Here E replies 'no' to AK's suggestion that she has a TV in her own room, but she immediately goes on to say where she does have a TV in her house. Note that her friend G, who is sitting next to her, also replies to AK's question but, immediately after E's head shake, she turns to E and says 'Nella stanza...' as if to remind E where her TVs are in her house. E's 'si' that follows her head shake appears to be, thus, a response to G's reminder. Then she goes on to explain where the TV is in her house.

Example I.4 is taken from *Bocce I*, a recording of a conversation among four men, all members of a *bocce* (indoor bowls) club. Here Giovanni has asked Enzo why a certain Ninuccio, who was absent from the gathering because he was making a telephone call, had come back to obtain a certain telephone number. Sandro intervenes to explain:

Example I.4. *Bocce I* 7.42.

- S: Non sapev' 'u numero' stev' sotto il manifesto  
He didn't know the number, it was at the bottom of the poster
- G: Già ten' un 'nata?  
He already had another?
- S: <++> Tenav 'na numero Salerno ventitre, sacc' a chi telefonava.  
He had the number Salerno twentythree, who knows who  
he was telephoning.

Here Sandro does a head shake before speaking in response to Giovanni's last question. In this case, it seems, this head shake is a 'no' in response to G's question. S replies, that is, that N did not have another number. He then immediately goes on to say what number he does have.

In Example I.5, from *Commerciante* (a recording made in Torre del Greco in 1996 of a street vendor and friends playing cards), P and T are partnered against A and V in a game of *tresette*. The two teams are competing for *aperitifs*. The loser of a given round will buy the other an *aperitif*. A round has just concluded and P calculates what his side has won:

Example I.5. *Commerciante* 36.26.

P: Uuu un aperitivo è andato (.) moo andiamo per il secondo  
Ehh one aperitif gone (.) now we go for the second

V: <++> Stammë sempë 'u primmë aperitivë siammë  
We are still at the first aperitif, we are

P: [Holds up his two hands to show with extended fingers the points he claims he has won]

V: <++>

A: Mo tien 'u tapp  
Now you have the bottle-top [i.e. you will be the one to buy the aperitif].

Here V's response to P's claim is an immediate 'no' which he gives, however, only gesturally – as a head shake combined with a manual gesture of negation (in this case he holds up his hand with the palm facing outwards towards his interlocutor in a kind of 'N-gesture' – see Kendon, *Forthcoming* for an account of this). This is followed by an explanation. P then responds by showing on his fingers the points he is claiming, but this, also, receives a head shake from Vincenzo, again a 'no' only in gesture, therefore. A, V's partner in the game adds in words what will be the consequences for P of V's 'no' – namely, that he is still the one to buy the aperitif.

These five examples illustrate some of the different circumstances in which a person may use only a head shake to say 'no.' Let us note some of the features of these examples in order to suggest what some of the factors may be that govern the choice of head shake only as a way of saying 'no.' In both examples I.1 and I.2 we deal with very young or young persons in a situation where a question has been put to them, in each case by someone much older than they, that could make them the centre of unwanted attention. In Example I.1 the little girl is asked to confirm where she lives when, in fact, she does not live where the questioner had assumed she did. In I.2 T, who has been asked if she knows cooking, appears embarrassed at the expectation that she might have to describe a recipe (E does describe a recipe and T does too, later, after E has done

so). Her embarrassment seems evident from the way she lowers her head at the end of her first head shake. It may well be that using a head shake by itself, in these circumstances, is a less direct, a less than fully fledged mode of response. In the case of I.2, in particular, T shakes her head not only to say that she does not know cooking (which is not really true) but also to say that she refuses what will be expected of her if she does admit to knowing cooking. Using the head shake alone, however, allows her a less direct way of displaying this refusal, and thus allows her a not so direct rejection of the suggestion or invitation that M implies by her question.

In Examples I.3 and I.4, in contrast, from the context of the dialogues in each case, it is clear that it is more interesting to the questioner to have positive information about where TVs are to be found (I.3) or about who N was telephoning and why (I.4), rather than to know that a TV is not in E's bedroom or merely that N did not have 'another number.' Thus, for the respondent, what is more salient is the positive information to be provided, not the 'no.' So here a head shake alone suffices, it is a response that clears the way for the provision of the information really required but is not the focus of the exchange.

Finally, in I.5, a head shake alone is used to say 'no' to an opponent in a game who is claiming that he is further ahead in the competition than in fact he is. For V, who is sure of his position, it is enough just to indicate in a silent manner his rejection of the position claimed by P. Furthermore, in such a potentially litigious situation (albeit always, in this case, a friendly one), a head shake by itself is perhaps a response which is reduced in its directness and explicitness. To add a verbal component here would, perhaps, be too 'strong' at this moment and could contribute to an escalation of the dispute. Using a kinesic response alone perhaps contributes to avoiding this.

In interpreting each of the foregoing examples, we have drawn upon a notion of what might be referred to as 'communicative explicitness.' In each case, it seems, the kinesic response is employed by itself because it is the 'lesser' way of giving a response. In I.1 and I.2, the respondent, by using the head shake alone, can avoid a reply that would place her closer to the attentional centre of the interaction. In I.3 and I.4 the head shake alone is sufficient in a circumstance where what is salient is the positive information. The 'no' is not really the focus of the dialogue in these cases. Finally, in I.5, although the 'no' is certainly at the focus of the exchange, for V who is sure of his ground it is enough to use a kinesic 'no' and in doing so he can hope to avoid the noisy discussion that could (and sometimes does) ensue in this context.

Needless to say, these are but tentative suggestions. Our purpose is to draw attention to the fact that head shakes can be used by themselves and to mention some of the factors that may govern when they are so used. It seems to us that the idea of a scale of 'communicative explicitness' may apply here and is, in any case, a notion that is probably of importance in explaining why and when people use certain gestures.

**II. Head shakes combined with a verbal 'no.'** It is common for the head shake to be used in combination with a verbal 'no.' We now describe a number of examples to illustrate this.

In Example II.1, taken from the Parochial meeting at Portici, a nine-year old, A, is describing the animals her grandfather has in his house. She mentions that he has many birds. MG, the Adult Leader, asks if they are free:

Example II.1. Portici 2001 Stanze 4.57.16

MG: Sono liberi?  
They are free?

<+>

A: No, stanno nelle gabbie  
No, they stay in cages

Here the head shake, a single left-right movement, occurs precisely as A says 'no.'

In Example II.2, also from the Parochial meeting, AK, the camera operator, has been asking E about the things she has at home. Here he asks her if she has real animals:

Example II.2. Portici 2001. Stanze 1.36.21

AK: Ha animali reali?

<++/++>

E: No

Here E does two left-right head shakes, the first over 'no' and the second one after she has stopped speaking. Note that, in this example, the question is whether there are real animals or not. And if there are not, as is the case here, there is nothing more to be said. In, in II.1, on the other hand, the question is about how the birds of A's uncle live, not whether there are any birds or not. Hence, if the birds do not live freely, how they live must yet be explained. In II.2, since there are no real animals, there is nothing more to be said and E's response closes a phase of the dialogue. AK's next move is to ask her to describe what kinds of toy animals she has. Given this, the repetition of the head shake

in silence after the 'no' could be a way of mitigating the abruptness of E's response. It could also be that the idea that E might have real animals is, to her, a very unlikely idea, so that the second head shake serves as a kind of emphasis, as if she might say "No, indeed I don't!"

In other cases where the head shake continues beyond the 'no' the speaker follows the 'no' with an expanded negative expression. Thus in Example II.3 M denies S's claim about the origin of a certain clock. He commences his head shake at the same time as he begins to say 'no' but continues it through the subsequent phrase 'it didn't'.

Example II.3. SMC .

S: [indicating a clock on the wall] that came from Charlie Douglas

M: What one?

S: That one of y'r dad's

M: Not that one

S Grandad's

<+++++++>

M: No it didn't

M, in first denying the origin for the clock that S claims, suggests that there might be some other clock in the house that came from Charlie Douglas. S continues to insist on claiming this origin for the clock she first indicated, however, and M's denial is now correspondingly more emphatic. The head shake introduced here is used as a way of making more prominent the denial, given that the clock in question has now been specified rather precisely. Under some circumstances kinesic expressions are added to verbal expressions when a speaker is re-stating something for the purposes of clarification and M's head shake used here in relation to his second, more complete denial, may be an example of this.

In Example II.4 we see illustrated another way in which a head shake may be extended beyond the 'no'. Here it extends over the explanatory phrase that follows the 'no'. This example is taken from Bocce I, where a robbery at the Bocce club is being discussed. Peppe is asking Giovanni if certain doors could have been open:

Example II.4. Bocce I 7.52.34.

P: No ricit 'nata cosa. I port pu' dint là senn aperte?

No your saying something else. The doors inside there are they open?

Embe' kill addret 'a port [.....]

Well that behind the door [.....]

G: Quale porte, 'ncoppa l'case vecchie?  
What door, above the old houses?

P: Eh!  
Yes!

<+++++++>

G: No, stann tutti chiusi, tutti sigilatti  
No, they are all closed, all sealed up.

In this example, the extended head shake comes at the end of an exchange in which there has been a progressive specification of what is being referred to. Thus the first speaker makes a claim about something (in this case a door that could have been open), the second speaker seeks greater specificity in which door is being referred to, in this case by making a suggestion as to which door it might be. When the first speaker agrees that he means that very door, G gives his 'no' and an explanation with an extended head shake. In this example, as in the previous one, the head shake is introduced when the object that is being referred to has been re-specified in a more explicit way. Just as the first speaker's claim comes to be more completely specified, so the second speaker's denial is made more prominent and visibly vivid by means of the head shake.

In other cases, the speaker may repeat the word 'no.' How head shakes may be related to repeated 'no's' is a matter of variation, however. In Example II.5, taken from a conversation (at a family dinner) in which R has been discussing her relations with colleagues at work, M suggests that a new colleague (who causes difficulties for R) arrived after another with whom she worked retired. R explains, however that the former colleague did not retire but transferred to another location. She denies M's supposition with 'No no', using a head shake with the first 'no' but not with the second. Then she follows with an explanation:

Example II.5. Pasqua 21.31

M: Poi, quella è andata in pensione ed è arrivata questa  
Then, she retired and this other woman arrived

<++>

R: No, no, invece, è andata a Como  
No, no, instead she went to Como

In this case, R's second 'no' is a repetition of the first and the kinesic component is dropped because, in this case, the repetition is an attenuation of the first expression rather than a doing of the 'no' as a repetition of the full 'move.' This is in contrast to what we see in Example II.6 where the repeated 'no' is, in each

case, a full re-doing of the 'no.' In this case, for each re-doing the communicative circumstances are slightly different. On the second occasion, the interlocutors are more fully oriented to one another.

This example comes from *Commerciante* 29.49, the card game. In the moment considered here, Peppe is claiming an advantage for his team over that of Vincenzo. He claims a certain score which Vincenzo denies:

Example II.6. *Commerciante* 29.49.

P: Tredici a venti

Thirteen to twenty

<++>

V: No no

T: Eh fajë sempë kestë

Eh he does always this!

<++>

V: No no

Here, that over the first 'No,' V lifts his head to look at P with his head tilted back. He shakes his head over the second 'no.' Then, as T (who is P's partner) makes his intervention (berating V for his unwillingness to accept the situation) T looks round at him, his third 'no' is uttered as he turns back to look at P once again. He then shakes his head again over his fourth 'no.' In each case it seems that the head shake is introduced, once the speaker has established a reciprocity in visual orientation (an 'interactional axis' as in Kendon 1973) with the interlocutor.

Example II.7, suggests a further complexity in the use of the head shake in saying 'no.' The example is taken from *Bocce I*, from a part of the conversation in which a robbery that had taken place at the club the day before is being discussed. Sandro recalls that he had noticed that certain louvre windows were open and he wonders if the thief could have entered through these. When he first raises the idea Giovanni, his interlocutor, is not sure what windows Sandro is referring to. As may be seen from the extract, when Giovanni denies that it would be possible for the thief to enter through the windows in question, he first confirms Sandro's observation that they were open. What is interesting here is that his head shake coincides with this confirmation, thus it coincides with the word '*Si* — Yes' although it refers to the 'no' that immediately follows:

Example II.7. *Bocce I*, 7.50.04.

S Quelle alette della prima finestra la eran' aperte?

Those wings of the first window, were they open?

- G Quali?  
What?
- S Io mo stando sul ballatoio dove stev' professore  
Just now standing on the balcony where the Professor was standing  
egg vist che c' stavano certi fierri delle alette  
I saw that certain bars of the wings  
che si appoggiano a  
that lean on
- <++>
- G Sì, no ma a là nun ponno tras' proprio  
Yes, no but in there they cannot get in at all

The foregoing examples show that in the use of the head shake in conjunction with the verbal expression 'no' there is no simple, inevitable relationship. Speakers can vary the way in which they place the head shake in relation to the 'no' they utter, they can extend the head shake beyond it, or they may, if they repeat 'no' use a head shake over one 'no' but not over the other. As we have tried to suggest in a comment on each example, what governs whether a head shake will be used or when it will be used in relation to 'no' or other negative expression is related to the 'rhetorical circumstance' of the utterance. Thus, the head shake appeared in relation to a second denial, where this second denial was in relation to something that had been more fully specified, and here it seemed as if it made the denial more salient (Examples II.3 and II.4). The head shake was used at the beginning of an utterance where the 'no' is the main, or initial response of the speaker to some suggestion or assertion (Examples II.5 and II.7). However, in another example (II.6) we saw the head shake used over a second 'no' in each case where the speaker's first 'no' had not been placed in the context of a fully developed 'interactional axis,' the head shake being added only when it would be directly seen by the interlocutor.

It will be seen from these few examples, then, that the head shake is not tied in some inevitable manner to any particular verbal expression, even though it can be used to mean 'no'. It is a kinesic expression in its own right, which the speaker may use in various ways in conjunction with what is being said in words to produce various communicative effects. This point, which is an entirely general one, and can be applied to all varieties of gestural expression (see Kendon, Forthcoming) will be further reinforced in relation to the use of the head shake in the sections to follow, where we explore examples of head shake use in contexts beyond those where a simple interpretation of the gesture as a 'no' is appropriate.



**III. The head shake and negative statements.** Often, when a speaker is making a statement that contains a negation, a head shake is also employed as a part of the utterance. However, in these cases we cannot say that it is the kinesic equivalent of 'no' or some other particular verbal negative, as in the previous examples. This is because the way in which the negation is expressed in words is variable and also because where, in relation to the words in the spoken discourse the head shake occurs, is also variable. As we shall see, the head shake itself is by no means necessarily performed contemporaneously with the verbal particles that serve as negations. In fact, as the examples to be presented seem to suggest, the head shake coincides with the verb or other verbal item that is being *modified* by the spoken negative particles the speaker is employing, rather than with these negative particles themselves. In both English and Italian the particles that serve to modify the verb or noun to create a negative, necessarily either precede or follow what they are modifying. Since, however, the head shake can be performed simultaneously with speaking, it can occur in association with the items to be modified. The head shake, in these instances, thus, functions in the same way as the verbal negative operators, but simultaneously with the lexical expressions to be operated on, not sequentially.

Example III.1 is taken from the recording SMC, where S and M, both natives of the same small Northamptonshire town, are reminiscing about their childhood for the benefit of A. M has just explained how, in his father's grocery shop, at Christmas time, he used to have a very large square cake, already iced and decorated, which would be sold to customers in pieces in sizes according to their request. A's utterance is in response to this description:

Example III.1. SMC 'Cake'

<++>

A: Yes, I've never (.) heard of that, yes.

She begins this utterance looking at S, M's wife. In the pause after 'never' she changes her orientation to look at M, whereupon she says 'heard.' — and as she does so she uses a head shake. The head shake in this case, thus, does not occur with the negative 'never' but with the verb it modifies.

Likewise, in Example III.2, also taken from SMC, we see the head shake coinciding with the verb rather than with the negative particle. Here S is explaining how, as a child, she and her friends very much enjoyed playing with a skeleton of a horse called 'Peter' that was set up in a small museum in the town. The man in charge of the museum, however, did not like the children playing with it.

## Example III. 2. SMC 'Pear'

&lt;++++++&gt; &lt;++++&gt;

S: He was not impressed with us playing with Peter

As she says 'not' she turns her head to her right in preparation for the head shake, but the head shake itself is executed as she says 'impressed'. There is a second head shake of smaller amplitude as she says 'playing.'

In Example III.3, which comes from OMUS, a recording of a meeting of the management committee of a small museum. Here the discussion is concerned with an artefact on loan to the museum which may have got damaged while it was on exhibition. J 2, the member of the committee who knows the owners of the object, is asked if she knows how they store it when they have it in their own home.

## Example III.3. OMUS (Angel). 1.29.19.

R: Do you know under what conditions they store it in their own home?

J2: Yes, they just store it in their other room.

&lt;++++&gt;

They live in one room, and the other room isn't heated, so that  
[????]\*

\*Speech unintelligible because of overlapping speech from two other speakers.

Here again, as will be seen, the head shake is placed over 'heated' rather than the auxiliary verb to which the negative particle is attached.

In Example III.4, which comes from SMC, the speaker, M, is describing one of the odd characters that used to be seen in the town when he was child. He describes someone known as 'Runny' Lee, who was a Catholic priest who used to run after small children, pick them up and kiss them, and then let them go:

## Example III.4. SMC

M: and he'd pick you and he'd kiss you.

&lt;+++++++&gt;

Of course this used to frighten us to death. He'd never hurt you (...)

Once again, head shake does not occur over 'never' but over 'hurt you'. That is, it occurs with the verb the adverb 'never' modifies, not with the modifying particle.

In Example III.5 the head shake commences in advance of the negative expression which here is the particle 'not' attached to the verb. Again, thus, the head shake coincides with the word that is the topical focus of the phrase (in

this case a noun) and it does not wait for the verbal expression of the negative. This example is again taken from OMUS, a recording of a meeting of the management committee of a small museum, when the discussion is concerned with an artefact that may have got damaged while it was on exhibition:

Example III.5. OMUS (Angel) 1.27.40

<+++++++>

JH: If it's in its own frame, the frame hasn't moved

Example III.6 again shows the head shake being performed simultaneously with the discourse the negative expression modifies, rather than with the negative expression itself, but here the structure is somewhat different. The speaker, who is giving a guided tour of an historic town in Northamptonshire, is talking about a very old wooden chair which had some ritual importance. The pertinent part of his discourse is structured as a question followed by an answer. His question is 'Where has the replica of the chair gone to?' and his answer is: 'I don't know.' Notice the head shake co-occurs with the question, and not with the answer, even though it is only in the latter that we see the verbal expression of a negative.

Example III.6. GB 2.54.56

GB: There is a replica of this as well,  
which used to be in the church, but they've re-ordered the  
church

<+++++++>

so I think it (.) quite where it is gone to now, I don't know

To close this section we give an example which illustrates how the head shake can be found to occur at the beginning of the discourse unit, even when what the speaker may be saying there does not express a negative. In cases of this sort, our examples suggest, the head shake *anticipates* the negative expression of the speaker where this is the main focus or theme of the discourse unit. It is our impression, from the few examples we have to hand, that this 'prepositioning' of the head shake occurs when the discourse unit is a turn unit that is a reply to a turn at talk of a different speaker, rather being a unit within a longer piece of discourse.

In Example III.7, thus, the head shake that is part of an utterance with a negative expression in it is pre-positioned where the utterance is given as a response to a question. The Example is from the recording *Commerciant*.

Here, one of the students engaged in filming the card-players comments that she has never understood how to play tresette. Peppe responds by a comment of his own in which he says that though he plays he does not really know how to play:

Example III.7. *Commerciante* 38.10.

R: Infatti non l'ho mai capito com'è che si gioca (.) cioè è la figura chee...

In fact I have never understood how it is that one plays (.) that is, is it the figure that...

<+++++><N>

P: Io gioco      ma non lo so come si gioca  
I play but I don't know how one plays

Notice that head shake comes over the first phrase 'Io gioco' – the speaker asserts 'I play' but with the head movement denies it – this denial anticipates the contents of the second phrase, introduced by '*ma-* but'. It is notable that this second phrase, just in association with '*ma*' also has a negative kinesic expression associated with it – in this case a hand gesture, marked here by <N>, in which an 'open' hand is held up in a vertical position, palm facing away from the speaker.<sup>4</sup>

The examples presented in this section have illustrated some of the different ways in which the head shake may be placed in relation to the spoken component of an utterance in which there is a negative expression. Further examples must be collected and examined before the patterns suggested here can be confirmed. However, as we saw in examples III.1 to III.6, the head shake may be placed in association with the verbal expression being modified by the negation, and it need not, and often, does not coincide with the verbal expression that performs this modification. On the other hand, in other circumstances, as when the negative expression is given as a response to another's question or comment, we can find the head shake moved to the front of the utterance, often considerably in advance of the negative expression that is to occur later in the discourse.

**IV. Head shakes that add meaning.** We pass now to consider examples in which the head shake is employed in the course of an utterance in such a way as to express a meaning *in addition to* any meaning that is being conveyed in words. This can show itself as an expression of some move in addition to the move already being made by the current utterance (as in making a statement and, in addition, answering a question), or as an expression of the speaker's attitude toward the contents of the verbal component of his utterance.

Example IV.1 is taken from OMUS, the recording made of a meeting of the management committee of a small museum in a small town in Northamptonshire, England, again from the discussion of the loaned artefact that may have been damaged. J1 asks J2 (who knows the owners of the object): ‘D’you think they’d like it repaired?’ to which J2 replies ‘Well, I think we’d have to ask them, uhm before that.’ As she gives her reply she shakes her head:

Example IV.1. OMUS 1.28.38.

J1 D’you think they’d like it repaired?

<+++++++>

J2 Well, I think we’d have to ask them uhm before that

Notice that the head shake occurs over that part of the phrase in which she refers to her own opinion. This suggests that the head shake here expresses an additional part of her reply, which here seems to be: ‘I do not know the answer to your question.’ Translating everything into words her reply would be thus, ‘Well I do not know what they would like, we must ask them first before we decide to try to repair it.’

Example IV.2 is a similar case. In a discussion in OCC, a recording of a meeting of a Cricket Club Committee in a small Northamptonshire town, the issue is what the Club should do regarding security for its new building. The Chairman takes the view that the Police would be the best people to advise them:

Example IV.2. OCC 8.27.16.

C: We’re obviously not experienced in terms of (.) that kind of property

<++>

Uhm (...) the police have far more dealings with isolated clubs,  
buildings generally

<++>

uhm (...)let’s go with their advice.

Here it is to be noted that there is no head shake in association with the first phrase of this discourse, even though there is a negative expression here (‘We’re obviously not experienced...’). The head shakes are seen in the next two phrases. In both cases they are placed in the little pause that follows the ‘filler’ ‘uhm’. Here, with the head shake, the Chairman precedes his verbally expressed recommendation with an expression which we might gloss as ‘we should not act on this independently.’

In Example IV.3 we see how someone, as he asks about something, as he explains what it is he wants to know, by means of a head shake he adds an indication as to why he wants to know it, which is that the information that he

has is mistaken and this is why he is asking about it. The example is taken from Bocce I and is from a part of the conversation which has to do with a mistaken telephone number. Giovanni has given Enzo a certain telephone number (needed for a telephone call that has to be made on behalf of Bocce Club business) and Enzo had left the room to check on it. He returns, suddenly, in some excitement, demanding that Giovanni tell him where he had obtained the number:

Example IV.3. Bocce I, 7.48.24.

E (speaking as he enters the room and stops in front of Giovanni):

Gioa' addo 'u pigliat 'stu cos, scusa.

Giovanni where did he get this thing, excuse me

<+++++++> <+++++++>

'stu 'stu numero 'i telefono (.) Dove 'u pigliat, Albert'?

this, this telephone number (.) where did he get it, Alberto?

As Enzo says ' 'stu numero 'i telefono' and again, as he says 'Dove 'u pigliat' he employs a head shake. This indicates here that the telephone number in question is mistaken. This Enzo does not say in words, he simply asks where the telephone number was obtained. The head shake provides a clue as to why he wants the information he is asking for. It adds the information that, for Enzo, the telephone number in question is not the one needed.

In other cases we may see how a speaker may use a head shake to express a negative attitude toward something that is being talked about. In Examples IV.4 and IV.5 the speaker comments negatively on something he himself is saying. In Example IV.6 the recipient of another's discourse shakes her head while the other is speaking, thus providing a comment on what the other is saying.

Example IV.4 comes from a conversation recorded with the proprietor of a shop that makes and sells terracotta figurines for the Neapolitan *presepe*.<sup>5</sup> The interviewer is asking the proprietor to give her opinion about what is to be a Neapolitan. She has said that Neapolitans feel ashamed of being from Naples. He asks why this is:

Example IV.4. LB 11.55.27

M: Per quale motivo? Cioè ci sono motivi?

For what reason? That is, there are reasons?

<++>

LB: (...) c'è troppa delinquenza. A Napoli non si può stare più.

there is too much delinquency. In Naples one can't stay any more.

&lt;+++++++&gt;

&lt;+++++++&gt;

C'è proprio, diciamo, proprio un caos, proprio esagerato.

There is really, let's say, really a chaos, really excessive.

Here, as will be seen from the transcription, the speaker commences with a head shake, then makes statements about the excessive delinquency and chaos that she believes exists in Naples. Her second statement to this effect also begins with a head shake (although this time simultaneously with the words '*C'è proprio*') and then she adds a head shake as a 'tag' after she has finished speaking. We interpret these head shakes here as expressions by which the speaker shows her rejection of the situation she describes. There seems no easy verbal translation for these head shakes, but they clearly express a negative attitude towards what is being said.

A rather similar use of the head shake is seen in the next example, taken from the recording *Commerciante*. Here one of the students filming the card players has asked if they play cards like this every day. P replies that business is bad, so they often play cards to pass the time while waiting for clients. The opposing partners play cards for aperitifs (the losing team must buy aperitifs for the winners). In the extract considered here, P comments that it is a bit sad that he spends his day chasing aperitifs in this fashion — rather than doing proper business. As will be seen, the head shake here serves to express this attitude:

Example IV.5. *Commerciante* 43.16.08

&lt;+++++++&gt;

P: Cacciare tremila lire di aperitivo. (...) È, è 'nu pokë triste.

Chasing three thousand lire for an aperitif. It is, it is a little sad.

Here the head shake coincides with the word '*aperitivo*' which is, one might say, the word that refers to the focus of the situation he is talking about, and it is this that he decries, it is this situation that he rejects or would like to say 'no' to.

We see a similar use of the head shake in the next example, although here the head shake is performed by the recipient of a discourse, not by the speaker. By placing the head shake where she does in relation to what the other person is saying she offers a comment on it — that it is a situation to be deplored. The example is taken from a recording made at a family dinner (*pranzo*) and the discussion has turned to the efficiency and convenience, or lack thereof, of the means of public transport in the area. The speaker, M, is explaining how sometimes she misses a bus that is supposed to connect with a train:

## Example IV.6. Pasqua 22.58

M: Spesso, poi, due volte la coincidenza non c'era,  
 Often, then, two times, the connection was'nt there,  
 ho dovuto chiamare mi amico l'assessore,  
 I had to call my friend the councillor,  
 povero Cristo, ho detto  
 poor fellow, I said

R: <+++++++> <+++++++>

M: 'vienimi a prendere perchè se qua mi metto a piedi qua arrivo domani!  
 'Come and fetch me because if I start to walk from here, I'll arrive  
 tomorrow!'

Here it will be seen how R uses a head shake (a slow rather large amplitude head shake) at the same time as M reaches the point where she explains that if she were to walk home from the station it would take her until tomorrow to arrive. The head shake serves as R's comment on what M is saying, a comment which can be interpreted as recognizing the negativity of the situation she describes — that the buses do not run properly, that as a result one is left with no means of getting home except on foot. Once again it is impossible to find a verbal formulation that can precisely capture the force of the comment made by the head shake, although it seems clear that negativity is the most salient component of the attitude being expressed.

**V. Head shakes and implicit negation.** A head shake is often employed simultaneously with speech where there is an *implicit negation* in what is being said. The first example shows the head shake in use with an expression in which the speaker implies that there are no other possible courses of action for someone. It is taken from *Commerciante*, where P is talking about his son who, according to him, does not have much will or initiative of his own. In his view, then, the only thing for him to do is to join the *Guardia di Finanzia* (the branch of the Italian police that enforces financial laws):

Example V.1. *Commerciante* 47.31.55.

<+++++++>

P: tu si tienē 'a fracētummē inkorporatē, sulē 'u finanzier può fa  
 If you have a basic lack of will-power you can only be a *finanziere*

As he says '*sulē 'u finanzier*' he shakes his head as if to express the implied negative ('nothing else').



Example V.2 illustrates something very similar. This is taken from a conversation in the heart of the ancient centre of Naples in which an artisan (who makes *presepe*) is asked to discuss what is involved in being Neapolitan. The interviewer suggests that he describes a typical Neapolitan recipe. He has some difficulty in thinking of one:

Example V.2. AS 12.31.24.

<+++++++>

A: (...)Eh sulè 'o spaghetti agljè e nogljè, maccarunè c'a'pummerolè fresché

Eh only spaghetti garlic and oil, pasta with fresh tomatoes.

He begins his response with a head shake which continues over 'Eh sulè — Eh only' — again, with this 'only' there is the implication of 'nothing else' or some other expression that indicates that he cannot think of any other recipes.

Example V.3 illustrates the use of the head shake in conjunction with an expression such as 'I *could* do X, but I *will* do Y' — where the implication is, of course, 'I will *not* do X'. This example is taken from a recording made near Salerno of a family dinner. R has been complaining about a difficulty a colleague has caused her at her work, regarding a lock on a cupboard. G suggests that she could on her own get the lock changed, but R replies that she would rather confront the colleague about it directly:

Example V.3. Pasqua 13.23.

G: Ma non lo potete fa cambià 'stu coso?

But couldn't you change this thing?

<+++++++>

R: Eh! Sì! Lo posso far anche cambiare,

Eh! Yes! I can indeed change it,

<++>

però (..) io quello dissi un altro giorno: 'dammi le tue chiavi'

however I said [to her] one day: 'give me your keys'

Here we see head shakes (very brief and restricted in amplitude though they are) performed as she says 'Lo posso — I can do it' — the head shake here expressing the idea that she will not in fact do it, which becomes clear as soon as she says 'però' — when we also get another head shake.

Example V.4, this time an English example, shows the head shake in use with the expression 'obviously.' If something is 'obvious' the implication is that

there is no need to discuss it or ask further questions about it. In this case the speaker refers to an Englishman who had insisted on building a house in the English style with English materials in New York. Someone who could do this was ‘obviously’ rich:

Example V.4. GB 2.14.04

GB: [he] insisted in the nineteen thirties that he would have a building in the English style

<+++++++>

with English materials. He’d obviously got plenty of money because he had all the stuff shipped out there

The head shake, well articulated of wide amplitude, is employed just over the words ‘He’d obviously got.’ We suggest it expresses the negation that ‘obviously got’ implies here, which is that one does *not* have to ask whether the man had enough money or not.

**VI. Head shakes and Universal statements.** When people make statements which are to be understood as having no exceptions we also see that a head shake is often used. Once again, we suggest that the use of the head shake in such contexts can be accounted for in terms of the idea that a statement with no exceptions carries with it the implication that anything else that might be said about the topic of the statement is to be denied. Thus, when as in Example VI.I, the speaker says: ‘If you need *any* help, I’m here to help’ the implication is that there are *no* kinds of help-needs that will *not* qualify for help. Likewise, in Example VI.2, a speaker is talking about how stone from demolished buildings will be used again in other buildings, if it is of good quality. He says that such stone is re-used ‘because it will last forever.’ He shakes his head as he says this, and this is because of the negation implied by his statement: good quality stone will *not* decay, it will *not* become unusable.

Example VI.I is taken from a recording made at an ‘activity day’ at a small museum in a small town in Northamptonshire. The speaker is an adult who has explained to children how to make medieval helmets out of cardboard and she remains available to them to help them in this task:

Example VI.I. OMUSACT 2.29.03

<++>

J: If you need any help, I’m here to help

The head shake occurs just with the word ‘any.’



Likewise, in the same recording, S is recalling the window displays that she remembers in the shop windows of her childhood. She says that these displays were “really wonderful” and shakes her head as she says “wonderful”:

Example VII.2. SMC

S: But uh the window displays with food uhm in them  
often it was pretend, wasn't it, but, from what they did then, yes

<+++++++>

uhm they used to look really (...) wonderful, didn't they?

This association between head shakes and superlative or ‘intensified’ positive assessments has been previously noted by M.H. Goodwin (1980), Schegloff (1987) and McClave (2000). Goodwin suggests that this kind of head shake be treated differently from ‘negation’ head shakes and should be regarded as an ‘assessment marker.’ McClave shares this view and suggests that the occurrence of a head shake in these environments be understood in terms of the idea that the gesture expresses ‘totality’ or ‘inclusion.’ However we believe that it is not necessary to say this and that the head shake used in these environments, as in all the others we have described so far, are also giving expression to a negative. In these cases they express the implied negative that is often present in evaluative statements, whether positive or negative.

When someone evaluates something in an extreme fashion, there is often the implication that what is being evaluated is valued to a greater extent than other exemplars in the class. The implication is that these other exemplars are either not equal to the thing being evaluated or cannot exceed it in the value attributed to it. Thus, when M says of the rabbit pie that it was “marvellous” he may imply that there are no pies more marvellous. Window displays that are “really wonderful” may be regarded as window displays that are as wonderful as any window display can ever be. The implied negatives here are: “There are no pies more marvellous” or “there are no window displays more wonderful.” We suggest that the head shakes observed in Examples VII.1 and VII.2 express this type of implied negation.

Further, we suggest, head shakes used in this way function as ‘intensifiers’ just because they make reference to such an implied negation. For example when, in the recording Texas Th a speaker who is describing her visit to a school in China declares “The children were charming” and shakes her head as she does so, the head shake here has the effect of intensifying the evaluation, as if she had said “really charming” or “so charming.” The head shake has this effect because it implies that the children could not have been more charming.

## Example VII.3. Texas Th. 00.31.10

S: And the children are given this by the government so that they can excel.

<+++++++>

The children were charming.

One observation that supports this suggestion is that speakers often do use an explicit negative when they make an extreme positive evaluation, and head shakes are often seen used in such cases. For example, if I am telling you about a sunset that deeply moved me I may say: "It was an extraordinary sunset!" But I might equally well say "There never was a sunset like it!" or "I never saw such a sunset!" or "it was an incredible sunset!" An example may be cited from Texas Th. The speaker is describing the gardens that she had seen in Japan. She says:

## Example VII.4. Texas Th. 03.28.24

S: The gardens. I mean it was every leaf was entering into its maturity just so.

I just went "Ahh!"

<+++++++>

I never saw anything more beautiful in my life.

And as she says "never saw anything" she shakes her head.

Another kind of explicit negative that is used when expressing an extreme evaluation is one in which the speaker claims that the object being evaluated was so beautiful, so marvellous, so extraordinary, that the interlocutor can have no conception of it. Thus of the marvellous sunset that I saw I might say: "You cannot imagine how beautiful the sunset was!" Once again, in such cases, a head shake is often observed. An example is provided by Example VII.5, which comes from a recording known as Portiere F. In this recording a somewhat elderly Neapolitan is talking about what it used to be like in Naples during the war. He participated, he said, in the Neapolitan resistance to the German occupation of the city at the end of the Second World War, but then goes on to say that, later, he spent time in Germany and he found that the Germans were very kind to him, so kind, indeed, that it is not possible to conceive of greater kindness. As he expresses this idea he shakes his head (and also uses a manual gesture common in negation environments: open hand, palm away, moved laterally, here marked in the transcript as <\*>).<sup>6</sup>

Example VII.5. Portiere F. 04.32. \*\*N-gesture, +++Head shake.

<++++++>

<\*\*\*\*\*>

P: e le azione che ho avuto dai tedeschi, non può immaginare,  
and the actions that I have had from the Germans, you cannot imagine  
quelle che non ho avuto, dai napoletani  
these [actions] I have not had from the Neapolitans

Extreme evaluations, we suggest, often imply the idea that the object being evaluated is ‘is more than you can know’ (and this is why, when people say them, you often get as a response exclamations such as ‘You’re kidding!!’ or ‘Oh no!’ or ‘was it really?’). This ‘negative’ is sometimes made explicit, as we see in Example VII.5, but it also often implied and this it is that is expressed by the gestures of negation that are often associated with expressions of extreme evaluation. Statements of intensified evaluation challenge the other’s experience which can provoke counter-claims or expressions of disbelief in the recipient. Gestures of negation such as head shakes in these environments, thus, serve as a kind of denial in anticipation of such potential counterclaims or expressions of disbelief.

However, there is also an implied negative, similar to that which we noted for statements which admit of no exceptions, when people use the comparative superlative. In such cases, where one says, for instance, that something is the best, the implication is that nothing can equal it. Or when one says that something is “absolutely marvellous” the implication is that nothing can be more marvellous. And so it is that, in such cases, we may observe a head shake in use. Two examples may be given in illustration.

In Example VII.6 taken from one of the Neapolitan interviews, the speaker, a woman, comments on the various characteristics of Neapolitans — their generosity, but also their skill in thieving:

Example VII.6. DSGA 20.34

<+++++++> <++++++>

C: Come in tutte le cose ‘o napulitanè è il migliore  
As in all things the Neapolitan is the best

The implication of what she says here is that no other people are as good as the Neapolitans in these skills.

In Example VI.7, taken from a recording of a conversation among four young women undergraduates at a large urban university in the Eastern United

States, one speaker refers to a famous baseball game that was “absolutely fantastic” the video-recording of which was being re-broadcast:

Example VII.7. ES

S: We’re recording a video for Josh. There’s apparently a baseball game

<++++++>

that was done ten years ago that was (...) absolutely fantastic

Here the implication is that there can be no other baseball game more fantastic than this one.

Speakers also use head shakes when they express evaluations using the absolute superlative, however. In these cases we suggest that the head shake *adds* to the expression and carries with it the same implication that would be carried were the speaker to use a comparative superlative.

Thus In Example VI.8. taken from one of the Neapolitan interviews, the speaker claims that Naples is a very beautiful city:

Example VII.8. LB 11.55.50

<++++>

<+++++++>

LB: Napoli (.....)è una bellissima città

Naples is a very beautiful city

Here the speaker uses a head shake with the absolute superlative ‘*bellissima*.’ We suggest that, by doing so, she adds the implication that there are no cities *more* beautiful than Naples.

Again, a speaker describes an aunt she used to visit as “very very old”. She shakes her head as she does so:

Example VII.9. SMC (‘cheeses’) S.

<+++++++>

S: she was very very old

and by using the head shake here she implies that her aunt was as old as it is possible to be or that there can be no others who are older.

In these ways, then, we can account for the so-called “assessment” head shake in terms of the idea that by using it the speaker can refer to or bring into play one or other of the *negatives* that are so often implied in extreme evaluations. In this way we can account for why the head shake can serve as an ‘intensifier.’

**VIII. Head shakes used as a speaker comment on speaker's own speech.** The head shake is used as a means by which a speaker can comment on his own utterance, as in self-corrections, or as when the speaker expresses doubt about what he is saying or doubt as to whether he has responded to his interlocutor appropriately. First we cite an example which shows a speaker using a head shake in relation to a self-correction in her speech. The example comes from SMC, in which the participants are describing memories from their childhoods. Here S is recalling where a farm once was, where now there is a housing estate.

Example VIII.1. SMC (Pear)

<-++->

S: Because where Millfields (..) is gro- eh the the built the um Millfield's estate,

A: Ye-es yes

S: the housing estate, that was school land, wasn't it?

M: Yeah

The speech immediately after the filled pause marked by 'um' is fluent. Immediately after the 'um' the speaker appears to have found a correct way to refer to the housing estate, and she is able to conclude her question to M, which is to confirm that where the housing estate known as Millfield's estate is now established, is where land once belonging to a school was used for farming. In the first part of the discourse there is much evidence of the speaker's confusion. At the point where she introduces the filled pause marked by 'um' here, also, she shakes her head, at the same time she also closes her eyes and moves her hand (at that moment extended forward) back and forth rapidly in an action reminiscent of an action one might use to rub something out. It is as if, in this moment, she has reached the point where she can complete correctly what it is she wishes to say and here she indicates that what she had tried to say before should be cancelled. The head shake here gives expression to that cancellation.

The other examples we cite in this section, which show speakers using the head shake as if in commenting on their own discourse, all pertain to the use of the head shake at moments when the speaker gives evidence that he cannot be sure of what he is saying, that what he is saying is a guess or an approximation. For example, a head shake is often used when a person makes an estimate about something. Thus, in Example VII.2, JS, a proprietor of a Public House, is describing his work and in the extract cited here he talks about the business in the restaurant he runs as part of the pub.



Example VIII.2. JS 2.17.54.

P: D'you serve many meals here at all?

JS: Yeah we're very (.) very busy with lunches

<+++++++>

especially (.) we at the weekend we can do (..) a hundred lunches at  
a(.) a day

Here the speaker uses a head shake as he commences the part of his discourse where he gives an estimate of the number of lunches he can serve in a day. What he says here is his guess, it is not a definitive figure. This seems clear from his use of the expression 'we can do' and also from the brief pause that precedes the figure that he gives. To be noted, then, is the use of the head shake which, as will be seen, occurs over the first segment of the discourse which introduces the guess.

The next example is taken from SMC. The discussion has turned to old clocks and A, who is has been asking S and M to tell their reminiscences recalls that she, too, possesses an interesting old clock that was made in the town where S and C had grown up. She tries to give the date of its manufacture:

Example VIII.3. SMC

A: I don't know what date it would have been

<+++++++>

eighteen twenties or eightee-e-n... something like that

In this example the head shake occurs over the very estimate that is being given. If the head shake can be regarded as an indication of the speaker's uncertainty — which would receive the verbal expression 'I don't know,' it is notable that in this example the head shake does not occur over that verbal expression, which is present here, but over the very expression that is modified by the expression 'I don't know.' This reminds us of the phenomenon, already noted in our discussion of the head shake in association with negative expressions, in which the head shake coincides with the expression the negative expression modifies and not with the verbal negatives.

In Example VII.4, taken from GB, the recording of the guided tour, the speaker seeks to characterize an institution whose history he has been describing. It is clear from the hesitation that is present just before he gives a label to the institution, during which we see a 'lip-pout' (a gesture commonly seen when people are doubtful about something),<sup>7</sup> that the label he does use is the best he can find, but he is not completely satisfied that it is the correct label. And here, likewise, we see a head shake being used:

## Example VIII.4. GB 2.37.54

GB: When we come to talk about the Oundle Schools,  
 which we shall do in a moment or two,  
 Similar foundation, originally for seven bedesmen  
 or men who would say prayers for the benefactors  
 <lip pout> <+++++++>  
 plus (...) um (.) an educational establishment

Here the head shake occurs over 'establishment.' At the time in the history of the institution he is talking about, in his view it was not correct to call it yet a 'school' — so he seeks some other expression. Notable here is the placement of the head shake at the end of his utterance, in association with the use of a terminal falling intonation. The head shake here can perhaps be interpreted as a kind of comment by the speaker on what he has just said, as if he were to say 'I do not know if what I have just said is correct.'

The last example to be described here also suggests the use of a head shake as a way of commenting on the speaker's own performance. In this case the speaker has sought to answer a question that has been put to him, but is uncertain as to whether he has fulfilled the expectations of the questioner. The example is taken from AS, one of the series of Neapolitan 'interviews' in which Neapolitans were asked to talk about what it means to be Neapolitan. He has just been asked to say what are the characteristics of Neapolitans:

## Example VIII.5. AS 12.28.59

A: Il napoletano ci ha tutto. La bellezza, la sincerità, è marijuolë, è  
 lavaratorë.  
 The Neapolitan has all. Beauty, sincerity, he is a thief, he is a worker  
 <++++++>  
 È un po' di tutto. Il napoletano è completo (.....)  
 He is a little of everything. The Neapolitan is complete.

At the end of this list of characteristics AS looks at his interlocutor, his brow slightly puckered, and shakes his head. We suggest that this head shake is a comment on what he has just said, as if to say 'I do not know if what I have said is the sort of thing you would like me to say.'

## Conclusions

As the foregoing series of examples has revealed, the head shake is used in a wide variety of discourse environments. Whereas it can be used as a kinesic equivalent of 'no' and can stand in, thus, or substitute for the use of this word, it also has uses that cannot be so simply interpreted. However, in all the cases we have reviewed it seems that we can interpret it as an *operator* that does semantic work similar in many ways to the work done by the various verbal particles of negation. As we have seen, because the head shake can be produced at the same time as speech it may be performed simultaneously with the parts of the discourse the operation of negation is to work on. However, as we also saw, the head shake can be prepositioned in relation to a unit of discourse and so can express in anticipation the negation that the discourse contains. It can also be placed after the unit of discourse, serving as a sort of 'tag' to the spoken component of the utterance, as a comment by the speaker on what has been said. We also saw, however, that a recipient can use the head shake as a way of making a comment on what a current speaker is saying. Further, we have seen that the head shake is also used in contexts where any negation is *implicit* so far as verbal expression is concerned — thus it can serve to bring out implicit negations in an explicit way. We sought to account for the occurrence of head shakes in association with statements without exceptions and with evaluative expressions, both positive and negative, in terms of this idea and suggested that it was, precisely, because they indicated the negation implied in any extreme or superlative statement, that they could serve as 'intensifiers' of evaluative expressions.

This preliminary investigation into the uses of the head shake encourages us to think that a much more thorough study of it would be worthwhile. We do not believe we have exhausted all the kinds of uses that may be observed for it and we do not claim to have reached the most adequate formulations in attempting to account for its use. However, we can already see at least one general implication of this investigation: it is that the gestural element, the head shake, is not to be understood simply as the kinesic equivalent of some unit of verbal expression. It appears as an expression in its own right which, furthermore, the speaker can place, as he places his words, as a component in the structure of an utterance which, it seems, is so often a *multimodal* construction in which the different modalities of expression available are *deployed* by the speaker as he builds a unit of expression according to the rhetorical needs of the moment.

## Notes

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1. Some discussion of the relationship between head shakes and so-called 'N-gestures' which are manual gestures using an open hand with the palm oriented away from the speaker and which are often used in expressions of negation will be found in Kendon (Forthcoming).
2. The specific technology employed is that offered by QuickTime in a Mac OS environment.
3. The speakers in the material recorded in the Provinces of Naples and Salerno use both various forms of Neapolitan and a regionalized form of Italian. In transcribing Neapolitan we have followed the conventions of D'Ascoli (1993) except that we have used 'k' where he would use 'ch' and we have used 'ë' to indicate where the vowel is atonal or indistinct, as commonly happens in final position (see De Blasi and Imperatore 2000). Apostrophes are used to indicate environments where certain word segments are dropped. I am indebted to Maria De Simone, Laura Versante, Teresa Stanzione, Carmen Pacifico and Maria Graziano for the Italian and Neapolitan transcriptions.
4. This is an example of a type of manual gesture that belongs to what, elsewhere, I have referred to the the 'N-family' in which an open hand is used, held so the palm faces away from speaker or downwards. As is described in Kendon (Forthcoming), gestures of this 'family' have in common a theme of 'stopping', 'interrupting' or 'cutting off' and in many contexts serve as gestures of negation.
5. The elaborate Christmas Cribs that are very popular in Naples
6. Another example of a so-called N-gesture. See Kendon (Forthcoming) for a full treatment.
7. This is, I think, a widely accepted idea. As far as I know, no one has undertaken a systematic context-of-use study of the 'lip-pout'!

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